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you stop
learning,
you start
dying.

—Albert Einstein

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20 by 20 means perfect eyesight, so by this programme and academia, we wanted to provide customers a clear vision of cloud and cloud-based services. Cloud is a metaphor for emerging technologies, and the programme 20 by 20 is also a driving force for us as we want to keep making it clearer.

Q. What came first the SIP or TIP?

A. SIP came first. Initially, it started as a technical paper contest. Then we shifted it to a demonstrable project contest, where the contestant needs to write an abstract, develop a prototype, and then demonstrate it to our technical panel. After this, we were questioning ourselves that what we can do next, and then we came up with the TIP part of the programme.

Q. The award money for SIP and TIP is 425,000 rupees, so how is it divided between the two different challenges?

A. The judgment is based on who provides a better solution to the problem and where will it be good to invest money. The money is awarded to three teams; the combination does not matter to us, but the kind of solution matters. In rarest cases, there is a tie between teams, and in such cases, we either split the money or introduce another award.

Q. How many of your employees get allocated to assist with the projects?

A. Roughly about five per cent of the employees are allocated to help with the projects. The engineers are not fully invested in the projects as their role is just to provide mentorship to the students and, in the end, the student has to complete it himself/herself.

Q. Besides this competition, any other platforms to engage with academia and students?

A. Yes, we do have a dedicated programme called UTFI, which can be accessed through the website called utfi.co.in. Through this, a student can apply for internships. This is the primary platform for our academia. Here we have uploaded some technical webinars, the latest technology trends, information about the contests, and other relevant information. This is not a charged service and anyone can access it.

Q. What are the challenges and opportunities that you are seeing during the pandemic regarding the hiring of candidates?

A. Our IT and recruitment teams worked really well during this pandemic, and they found out solutions very quickly to deal with the scenario. Now we interview candidates through digital mediums such as phone calls, interacting through video calls, learning through videos, etc. We were still hiring throughout the pandemic, and there was no change in the recruitment strategy, only the medium of recruitment was changed.

Q. Which kind of technology is expected to see a boom and which are the ones that are diminishing? Which technology would you suggest students bet on?

A. We believe in 'Inch wide and mile deep,' which means exploring all the possible technologies but, at the same time, understanding the core at a deeper level to become a thought leader in the subject. I think that there's a lot of scope in the digital transformation sector and the adoption of cloud technologies. Also, the technologies that involve data analytics study to make better and informed decisions, and will help in making the consumer future-ready, are expected to survive in the future. All types of emerging technologies like Blockchain, AIML, IoT, etc., are the area that I can bet on.

Q. What happens to the content and white papers that are shared with you? Do you release it, publish it on the website, or open source it?

A. Yes, we share the winning ideas on our website and retain all entries on our internal website. The engineers that are responsible to mentor the students gather all the idea in one place. Then we publish these ideas on our internal website under the category 'Cloud 20-20.' This enables all the engineers in our company to read these ideas, comment on them, and later try evolving a combination of ideas to develop existing technologies. Second, we try to file patents wherever possible.

Q. The program 20-20 exists in other countries as well, or is it just an India driven initiative?

A. Originally, it is an India driven initiative, but we are looking forward to ways in which we can run this programme in other countries as well. So, in the future, you might see it as an internationally running programme. **EFY**